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Top Skills

Program Management
Team Leadership
Leadership

Eric Ballester

The Rick Herrema Foundation • SOF Veteran • Military / First Responder & Family Advocate
United States

Summary

Eric Ballester serves as the Executive Director of The Rick Herrema Foundation (RHF), channeling a 20-year Special Operations career – including 10 combat deployments – into a new mission of service on the home front. A retired U.S. Air Force Combat Controller, Eric led and stood shoulder-to-shoulder with America's finest in every major conflict since 9/11. His time in uniform, which earned him accolades such as Special Operator of the Year, instilled in him a deep commitment to duty, teamwork, and country. Now in his second year guiding RHF, Eric treats this role as a natural extension of his military service – honoring the sacrifice of fallen comrades by strengthening the families they left behind. He approaches this calling with the same humility and resolve that defined his career in special operations, leading by example and always putting the mission first.

Despite these accomplishments, Eric is known for his grounded and humble leadership style. He is quick to credit the dedication of his team, volunteers, and the resilience of the military families themselves for RHF's success. Colleagues describe Eric as a servant-leader who listens first and leads from the front, fostering a culture of trust, transparency, and excellence. His ethos of continuous improvement – evident since his post-military years of earning a business degree, starting a small business, and volunteering as a nonprofit treasurer – infuses RHF with innovative yet mission-focused direction. Above all, Eric's genuine passion for the military family shines through in every decision. He creates an environment where everyone involved with RHF feels like part of a shared patriotic purpose.

Eric Ballester welcomes you to join him in this mission of support and gratitude. To learn more about the Rick Herrema Foundation and how you can get involved, visit www.RHFnow.org.

Experience

The Rick Herrema Foundation

Executive Director

November 2023 - Present (1 year 7 months)

Fayetteville, North Carolina Metropolitan Area

RHF provides fun, quality activities for active-duty families, prioritizing families reintegrating post-deployment. The activities are curated to help strengthen relationships and build community. Activities occur at our 50-acre park started by soldiers for soldiers and their families who are facing uptempo deployments.

Shields and Stripes

3 years 2 months

Startup Manager

April 2020 - May 2023 (3 years 2 months)

Gilbert, Arizona, United States

Shields and Stripes is a non-profit organization that serves our nation's heroes; Law Enforcement, First Responders, and Veterans. This 501c3 offers a 3-wk in-person 9-week telehealth program that utilizes psych therapy and fitness, wellness, nutrition, and physical therapy to treat service-related trauma.

A founding member and volunteer that Identified opportunities, raised funds, and planned/executed four programs to reduce veteran and first responder suicide—a positive impact on 26 military and first responders suffering from trauma. Recognized by all stakeholders as the most important asset/critical member of the entire organization.

• Non-profit founding member. Defined segmented problems, and solutions to create a holistic 12-week therapy program.

• Advocacy and program management leading a team of 12 clinical providers during three weeks of in-person holistic care.

• Board Treasurer. Developed local events fund-raising programs providing $100K towards wellness services.

Director of Public Relations

September 2022 - April 2023 (8 months)

Gilbert, Arizona, United States

Executes Shields and Stripes' external communication strategy defined by the president & VP by outlined objectives and priorities with communication. Earned organization the nomination as non-profit of the year. Evaluates and manage strategic partnerships. Synchronize efforts in collaboration with donor

relations and the marketing team. Leads a team that drives outbound public market awareness for the Shields and Stripes Brand through traditional and digital PR tactics, including but not limited to media & influencer relations, leadership, speaking engagements, and collaborative efforts on a local and national scale. Presents material to organizations for education and fundraising efforts.
• Craft thought leadership content and other marketing or public engagement materials.
• Manages local, state, and federal partner relationships/collaboration to maximize brand awareness and fundraising efforts.
• Identifies and secures opportunities for sustainment through donations, grants, and products/services.

The Honor Foundation
Fellowship
January 2020 - April 2020 (4 months)
Aberdeen, North Carolina, United States

The Honor Foundation (THF) is a unique transition institute created exclusively for Navy SEALs and the U.S. Special Operations community. We provide a clear process for professional development and a diverse ecosystem of world class support and technology. Every step is dedicated to preparing these outstanding men and women to continue to realize their maximum potential during and after their service career.

If you are looking for the one thing that makes THF special, it may be this: every decision we make is the product of co-creation with actual members of the Special Operations community. We seek their input constantly. We approach challenges the way they do. We strive to hold ourselves to their impeccable standards. We achieve because we follow the lead of the world’s highest achievers.

The Mission: "To serve others with honor, for life. So, their next mission is clear and continues to impact the world.

Specialties: • Operations • Leadership • Team Building • Strategic Planning • Logistics • Problem Solving • Budget Planning • Intelligence Analysis • Communications • Risk Management

Joint Special Operations Command
8 years 7 months

Program Manager
June 2017 - January 2020 (2 years 8 months)
724th Special Tactics Group Detatchment 1 - TS SCI

Section Chief / Cadre Lead

Program Manager for organizations top priority; Assessment, Selection & Operator Training course

10mo. 2.5M$ budget. Set performance standards for 4 subordinate Cadre Team Leaders supporting 3 week candidate professional, psychological, and extremely physical assessment. Optimized processes for cadre to train/lead 30 candidates from 100 assessed. Developed curriculum to improved processes for Elite 9mo. commando training: close quarters live fire, military parachuting, emergency medical treatment, night time operations.

Controlled 17 separate organizations to execute successful 2 week - day/night, air & ground live fire simulation training; supporting resources valued at 670M $. Controlled cross organization scheduling to execute 30 tactical iterations: 9 Students trained in 3 simultaneous training areas; zero safety incidents while integrating 7,000 rounds of live ammunition from fighter jets in close proximity to ground personnel. Innovatively shared cost with supporting units to reduce organizations exercise cost by 50%.

Crisis Manager
July 2011 - June 2017 (6 years)
24th Special Tactics Squadron - 7 Deployments to various locations - TS SCI

Element Leader

724th Special Tactics Group Combat Control operator provides training and technical assistance in the development of tactics, techniques, and procedures to ensure standardization across the Air Force Special Operations Command (AFSOC) Special Tactics community.

Crisis Management skills honed and tested in combat combined with exceptional abilities in leading multiple programs, tasks and priorities effectively and in a timely manner. Selected 2016’s #1 of 500 Special Operator Service Member of the year. Led Air Force Special Warfare team to directly support US Army Special Operations Forces & Naval Special Warfare Group conducting POTUS directed operations. Highly adaptive and innovative known to solve practical problems and get the job done.

Team leader to organizations highest decorated team of diverse experts in: technical rescue & command and control. Manages proficiency training and

manpower allocation to support global contingency operations the top 1% of Special Operations.

7 Deployments providing internal defense across cultural boundaries in austere environments. Expertly projected US & coalition air power in support of host nation objectives. Meritorious awards earned supporting Global War on Terrorism, Operation Inherent Resolve, Enduring Freedom & other campaigns.

USSOCOM

Emergency Management Specialist

June 2006 - June 2011 (5 years 1 month)

23rd & 21st Special Tactics Squadron - Iraq 07’ & 10' / Afghanistan 09' - TS SCI

Team Member

3 Combat Deployment in support of the Global War on terrorism. Synchronized the integration of aircraft in combat, support, & emergency medical evacuation operations. Provided global logistics to entire base; surveyed and controlled the re-supply zone to provide critical supplies for outpost of 250 US and allied troops.

Kean mental acuity displayed in chaotic situation. Synchronized medical evacuation and the delivery of precision bombs simultaneously. Controlled helicopter extraction of injured service members evacuated to higher care. Awarded meritorious citation for lifesaving action.

While deployed 6 months to support Operation Iraqi Freedom. Skillfully integrated aviation capabilities to support the liberation of Al Qaeda in Iraq from the town of Mosul. Earned Bronze Star medal!

United States Air Force

Combat Controller

April 2004 - May 2006 (2 years 2 months)

Hurlburt Field, FL. - Secret

Awarded Air Force Specialty Code 1C271, Combat Control Craftsman Special Operations Forces and certified FAA air traffic controller. Establishes support locations in austere environments to provide internal defense and humanitarian assistance in the joint arena. Specialize in all aspects of air-ground communication, including air traffic control, fire support, and command, control, and communications in covert, forward, or austere environments.

Concurrent with these equivalent civilian job descriptions as defined by the Dept. of Labor’s Dictionary of Occupational Titles (DOT), the Occupational

Information Network (ONET), and the Occupational Employment Statistics (OES):

•Air-Traffic-Control Specialist, Tower (DOT 193.162-018)

•Airplane Dispatchers And Air Traffic Controllers (OES 39002)

•Chief Controller (DOT 193.167-010)

•Command and Control Center Specialists (ONET 55-3015.00)

Education

University of Arizona, Eller College of Management

Executive MBA, Business Administration and Management, General · (August 2020 - May 2022)

Syracuse University

Certificate, Program Management Professional (PMP) certification · (2019 - 2020)

The University of Texas at Austin - Red McCombs School of Business

An Executive Education Certificate Program for Business Leaders, Texas Executive Education – Veteran Accelerated Management Program 2018

The University of Texas at Austin

McCombs School of Business

Mesa High School

High School Diploma · (June 1997 - June 1999)